PRESENTATIONS

Lessons and Conversations

YSoA Summer Program
June 1-19, 2026

RIA

1. Introduction
June 1



Julia Spackman facilitated a round of introductions, an overview of the schedule for the next 3 weeks, and discussed the format and goals of the program. The Fragas do Eume were presented as a living laboratory for understanding the complex relationships between ecology, production, and community. She explained how industrialization, depopulation, conservation policies, and changing land use have transformed the territory, while identifying opportunities to reconnect people and ecosystems.

Rather than seeking definitive solutions, the introduction emphasized developing thoughtful frameworks and embracing diverse systems of knowledge to propose regenerative, community-driven strategies. The territory was explained as an interconnected network of ecological, cultural, and economic relationships.



Manuel Rodríguez explained the importance of understanding the relationships and interconnections between people, communities, productive systems, companies, and stakeholders. He encouraged students to build a layered understanding of how the territory functions.

Manuel suggested choosing one or two topics of genuine interest and investigating them deeply; prioritize specificity and understanding over trying to predict the final outcome.



Ana María Durán Calisto urged students to let the territory guide their research instead of arriving with fixed questions. She urged the students to engage directly with the land and be inquisitive about biases in ontologies, axiologies, epistemologies, and knowledge systems.

She also highlighted ways of valuing ecosystems beyond extractivist views of the land, advocating for understanding biocultural synergies and ecological services.

2. Fundación RIA: Asking the Right Questions
June 1



Manuel discussed how meaningful design begins not with solutions, but with better questions. The students were encouraged to examine the connections between people, productive systems, ecology, governance, and the built environment, recognizing that territory is shaped by overlapping forces. Complexity was presented not as an obstacle, but as a condition to embrace through careful observation and collaboration.

A key message was that meaningful interventions begin by recognizing the existing capacities of a place. By working across multiple scales, from regional land management to local public spaces, and adapting methods of mapping and visualization, he explored how underused land, infrastructure, and community networks could be reactivated. Design was presented not as the creation of new systems, but as the careful strengthening of those already embedded within the territory.



A recurring theme was the importance of collaboration and interconnected thinking. Architecture, in this sense, becomes a process of learning alongside the people who inhabit a place rather than designing for them.

By visualizing circular relationships and adjacent possibilities, design becomes a tool for connecting entities to strengthen stewardship capacities within a place.



He advocated for an iterative approach to implementation, including small pilot projects and interdisciplinary collaboration. Continuous reflection was encouraged to provide opportunities to test ideas, manage risk, and inform larger strategies.

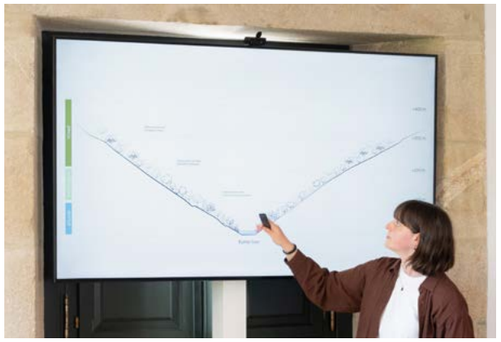
Ultimately, the goal is not simply to build, but to develop design approaches that respond to the unique dynamics of a territory while generating lasting value.

3. The Landscape of Fragas do Eume Natural Park
June 1



Lucía Escrigas presented the natural park as a living territory shaped by forests, rivers, villages, productive landscapes, and private ownership, where environmental protection must be balanced with local livelihoods. The future of Eume depends not only on conservation, but on governance. Rather than treating preservation as a restriction, she argues that it should become a framework for coordinated action.

Understanding the territory begins with understanding its actors. Municipalities, landowners, farmers, researchers, public administrations, and community organizations all hold different priorities, making mapping and fieldwork essential tools for revealing relationships, conflicts, and opportunities. Identifying what is missing can be as valuable as documenting what already exists.





Central to this approach is the use of pilot projects: small-scale interventions that test ideas, inform policy, build trust, and demonstrate how local actions can influence broader territorial strategies. Their value lies not only in successful outcomes, but in creating evidence through experimentation.

Ultimately, the challenge is one of clarity and collaboration. By improving access, coordinating fragmented ownership, and supporting productive communities alongside ecological protection, architecture becomes a means of managing complexity rather than simply preserving scenery.

4. Manuel Bouzas: Internalities
June 1



Manuel Bouzas approaches landscapes with the curiosity of a journalist, beginning each project by going into the field to observe, listen, and collect evidence. Rather than treating architecture as an isolated discipline, he investigates the social, material, and environmental systems that connect places across multiple scales. His work asks not only what a landscape is, but what forces have produced it.

Drawing from his *Internalities* research, Bouzas challenges conventional ideas of sustainability by shifting attention from operational efficiency to the origins and consequences of building materials. Every material carries ecological, economic, and territorial impacts that extend far beyond the construction site, linking cities to distant forests, quarries, industries, and communities.





Through mapping and photography, these often invisible relationships become legible. Wildfires, common lands, resource extraction, and industrial production are understood not as separate issues, but as interconnected expressions of the same territorial system. The landscape is read as a network of dependencies rather than a collection of isolated places.

This perspective reframes architecture as a practice of responsibility. By understanding where materials come from, how resources circulate, and who is affected by their use, designers can make decisions that strengthen local ecologies while revealing the broader consequences of the built environment.

5. Isabel Aguirre: Landscape Architecture
June 3



For **Isabel Aguirre**, landscape architecture is an act of careful observation rather than imposition. Drawing on her work at Parque de Bonaval, the Monastery of San Xoán de Caaveiro in Eume, and years of teaching, she describes design as a patient dialogue with the character of a place. Every intervention begins by understanding what already exists and asking how little is needed to reveal its qualities; its topography, vegetation, materials, water, and memory.



Rather than seeking uniformity, Aguirre embraces the irregularities of the landscape. Existing trees, exposed rock, drainage patterns, and traditional craftsmanship become guides for design decisions instead of obstacles to overcome. Materials are selected with equal care, respecting both their origin and the stories they carry.



Her approach offers a broader lesson: landscapes cannot be rushed. Time spent walking, observing, and returning to a site is as important as drawing it. Good projects emerge through patience, skepticism toward easy solutions, and a genuine commitment to caring for the places entrusted to us.

6. Review I: Biocultural Thinking
June 5



The discussion in this preliminary review challenged the tendency to separate ecological questions from social ones, emphasizing that resilient territories emerge through everyday relationships as much as through environmental performance. Shared infrastructures were presented as examples of how small-scale, collective systems can strengthen both resource efficiency and social cohesion.

A recurring theme was the importance of biocultural thinking: understanding that landscapes are shaped not only by natural processes but also by traditions, mutual care, local economies, and community practices. Informal networks of trust, such as parents providing childcare for neighboring families, illustrate how social relationships become an essential form of infrastructure that supports daily life.



The review also questioned an overly analytical approach to design. Complete knowledge is rarely possible, and waiting for certainty can prevent meaningful action. Rather than allowing complexity to become paralyzing, designers should use research as a foundation for experimentation, testing ideas, learning through implementation, and adapting over time.



Finally, the conversation contrasted different models of resilience. While self-sufficiency is often celebrated, true resilience may lie in systems of interdependence where shared resources, public support, and collective responsibility reduce vulnerability. The discussion suggested that designing for stronger social safety nets and mutual reliance can be as important as designing for individual autonomy.

7. Brais Lorenzo: Photojournalism in Galicia
June 5



Brais Lorenzo presented photography as a form of territorial research and cultural preservation. Through long-term documentation of rural Galicia, his work captures not only landscapes but also the everyday lives, traditions, and knowledge of the people who inhabit them. His photographs reveal how depopulation and changing land use threaten both cultural heritage and ecological resilience, while preserving visual narratives that might otherwise disappear.



His work demonstrates that photography can do more than document; it can communicate complex territorial issues in a deeply human way. By carefully constructing visual essays, Lorenzo connects local stories to global challenges such as wildfire, monoculture, abandonment, and climate change. Rather than focusing solely on loss, his images also reveal resilience and adaptation to new ways of inhabiting the landscape.



Lorenzo showed how photography can reveal the social, ecological, and cultural dynamics that conventional analysis often overlooks. His work reinforced the importance of documenting lived experience and amplifying local voices. He highlighted how meaningful design begins with a deep understanding of the people and places it seeks to support.

8. Review II: Designing for Rural Resiliance
June 8



A review with feedback from architects **Alfonso Bertran Gil** and **Fred Pearsall** was centered on the interconnected challenges facing rural territories: depopulation, land abandonment, wildfire risk, and the decline of traditional ways of life. The students recognized that these issues cannot be addressed independently; people will only remain in a place if the landscape can continue to support meaningful livelihoods. Understanding demographic trends and grounding proposals in real social and economic conditions were seen as essential starting points.

Rather than relying on new digital platforms, the discussion explored how existing regional economies and community networks could be reactivated. Mobile markets, shared events, and other place-based initiatives were presented as opportunities to strengthen local exchange while building relationships that are rooted in the territory rather than mediated through technology.



Education emerged as a powerful catalyst for territorial regeneration. The students proposed immersive programs that combine history, crafts, music, cuisine, conservation, and production within existing or abandoned buildings, allowing visitors to experience the landscape through direct participation. By engaging with local knowledge and cultural traditions, these initiatives can foster stronger connections between people and place.



Ultimately, the review advocated for a strategic approach centered on management rather than isolated design interventions. Reimagining the landscape means identifying overlooked resources, strengthening existing programs, and creating opportunities for collaboration across generations. Involving students in real territorial challenges was seen as a way to generate fresh ideas while ensuring that local knowledge and skills continue to be valued and shared.

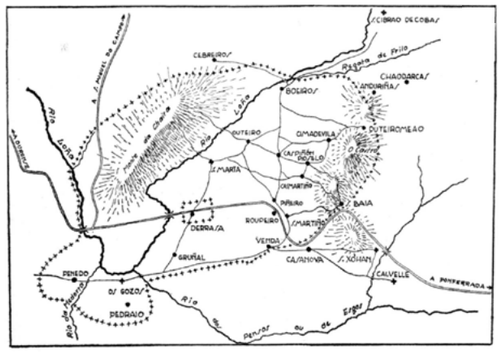
9. Pablo Gallego: The Unique Territory of Galicia

June 8



Pablo Gallego presented Galicia not as a collection of places, but as a living territorial system whose complexity can only be understood by reading the relationships between geology, water, climate, settlement, infrastructure, culture, and memory. Every map tells a different story, and no single representation is sufficient. Instead, cartography becomes a critical tool for revealing the hidden structures that shape how people inhabit the land and how those patterns have evolved over time.

For Gallego, culture is inseparable from territory. Settlement patterns, architecture, dialects, agriculture, and communal traditions all emerge from generations of adaptation to local environmental conditions. Understanding these relationships requires moving between scales, from regional systems to individual plots of land, while recognizing that every landscape is the result of continuous interaction between people and place.



A recurring theme was that landscapes should never be understood through images alone. Galicia's dispersed settlements, parish structure, communal lands, and agricultural systems reflect centuries of collective stewardship rather than isolated buildings or infrastructures. Community is embedded in the landscape itself, and preserving cultural identity depends on understanding these inherited territorial logics instead of imposing standardized solutions.

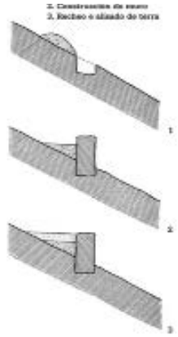


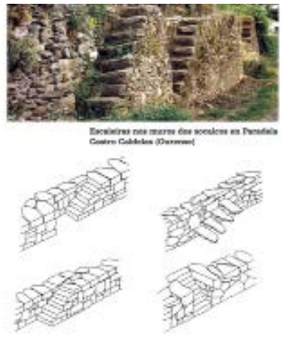
Gallego traced how industrialization, mechanized mobility, and monoculture have gradually reshaped Galicia's territory. Highways, changing economies, and the expansion of eucalyptus plantations have altered settlement patterns, weakening communal systems and transforming productive agricultural landscapes into fragmented forests. These changes occur slowly enough to become normalized, making them difficult to perceive without long-term observation.



While much of the lecture examined the consequences of extraction and fragmentation, Gallego ultimately focused on possibility. Galicia serves as a small laboratory whose challenges of depopulation, industrialization, climate change, and resource management reflect issues faced across the world. Reading the territory critically makes it possible to envision alternative futures grounded in local knowledge rather than universal models.

Throughout the presentation, mapping was presented not simply as a method of recording information but as a way of thinking. By layering hydrology, geology, ecology, infrastructure, ownership, and social systems, cartography becomes a means of discovering relationships that conventional planning often overlooks. Changing the representation changes the questions that can be asked.





The emphasis on multiscalar thinking, critical cartography, community knowledge, and territorial systems echoed many of the themes explored throughout the program. Rather than treating architecture as an isolated discipline, he demonstrated how meaningful design emerges from understanding the ecological, cultural, and historical processes that shape a place.



Ana Maria extended these ideas by encouraging participants to see territories shaped by profit-driven extraction not only as places of crisis, but as opportunities for transformation. Rather than accepting dominant models of development, she advocated for post-extractive futures rooted in biocultural systems, local knowledge, and alternative ways of inhabiting and caring for the land.

10. Review III: Reading Territorial Systems
June 12



The review with feedback from **Pablo Gallego** and **Lorena Bello** reinforced a central theme of the workshop: meaningful design begins with learning to read a territory. Echoing the emphasis on multiscalar thinking, critical cartography, community knowledge, and territorial systems, they argued that architecture emerges from understanding the combined ecological, cultural, and historical processes that shape a place. Rather than treating the landscape as static, the students were encouraged to see it as an evolving network of relationships that unfolds across space, time, and community.

Cartography was presented as more than a tool for documentation—it is a method of inquiry. By gathering data and spatializing information on layered maps, they can reveal hidden patterns, relationships, and opportunities. Rigorous representation allows complex territorial systems to become legible, transforming observation into a foundation for informed design.



The discussion also emphasized the importance of framing. Every project begins by identifying a meaningful problem and clearly articulating the constraints that define it, yet effective design avoids predetermined solutions. Instead, it establishes a framework that is open enough to accommodate adaptation, collaboration, and future change while remaining grounded in evidence.



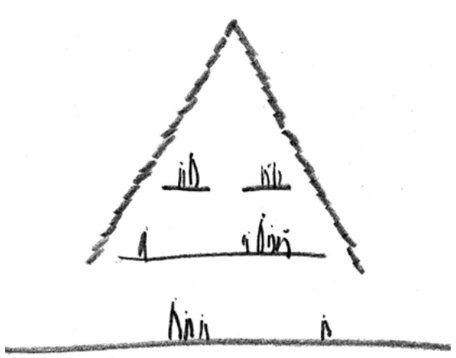
Finally, the students were encouraged to look first at what already exists. Underutilized infrastructures, local knowledge, and existing resources often hold greater potential than entirely new interventions. By recognizing and strengthening these latent relationships, the students could develop scalable strategies that create mutual benefit between communities, landscapes, and the systems that connect them.

11. Witoca: Bioarchitecture in the Ecuadorian Amazon
June 16



David Barragán (Al Borde Architecture) and **Fabio Legarda** (cofounder of Laboratorio Witoca) presented design as a tool for strengthening existing community systems rather than introducing external solutions. Working alongside Amazonian communities, Witoca is an agroforestry hub incorporating education and locally sourced construction techniques to create spaces that emerge from participation, local knowledge, and long-term relationships. Communities help define the projects themselves, ensuring that architecture responds to genuine needs.

A central idea was that conservation and production should work together rather than in opposition. Through skills training and the *chakra* model of ancestral agroecology based on high biodiversity, Witoka seeks to build economic resilience while protecting the forest. The long-term vision is for communities to fund their own social infrastructure, such as schools and libraries, through



The presentation also challenged conventional measures of development and poverty, emphasizing that prosperity cannot be understood through economic metrics alone. Instead, education, cultural practices, shared knowledge, and strong community networks were presented as equally important foundations for resilient territories.



Ana Maria connected these ideas to the broader role of the architect as a facilitator of relationships. She described projects as networks of interconnected stakeholders, where meaningful change emerges through trust, collaboration, and shared learning. Architecture becomes less about designing isolated buildings and more about creating the conditions for communities to thrive, adapting to local cultures, landscapes, and ways of life.

12. Review: Making the Invisible Visible
June 16

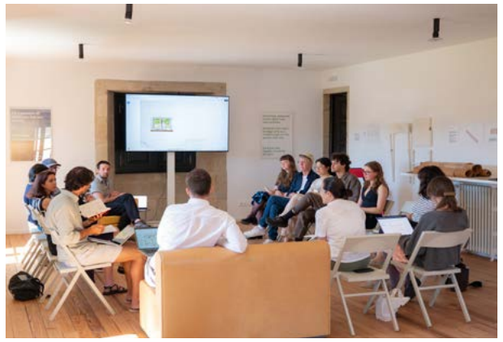


The review emphasized moving beyond identifying territorial challenges toward proposing tangible responses. Research becomes meaningful when it is projected into the real world through measurable interventions and visualizations that communicate both the scale of a problem and the potential impact of action. Data, historical evidence, and clear points of entry help make invisible conditions visible and encourage informed decision-making.

A central theme was the importance of relationships. Rather than designing systems based on *transactional* exchanges, the students were encouraged to make them *transformative* by strengthening the networks of trust and mutual support that connect people with one another and with their territories. The goal is to create experiences that foster long-term engagement rather than one-time interactions.



The discussion also highlighted the need to connect multiple scales of observation. Infrastructure, mobility, ecological succession, and historical patterns all shape the landscape, from regional transport networks to the subtle paths formed by grazing animals. Understanding movement—of people, resources, and ecological processes—reveals opportunities to rethink existing systems, while sections, mappings, and visual narratives help communicate these layered relationships.



Finally, the review encouraged designers to render a compelling vision of change. Drawings, photographs, and representations should not simply document existing conditions but communicate future possibilities with clarity and restraint. Small, strategic interventions—an architectural acupuncture—can catalyze broader transformations, while documenting disappearing landscapes, communities, and generations preserves the cultural memory that informs future action.

13. David Chipperfield: Reflections
June 16



Reflecting on the student's short-format Pecha Kucha presentations, **David Chipperfield** reflected on the importance of shifting design away from conventional notions of growth and progress, toward a deeper understanding of the consequences our actions have on society and the environment. Rather than viewing ecological and social issues as constraints to design, he argued they should become its primary driving force. For David, Galicia offers a unique opportunity to explore new ways of inhabiting territory.

He emphasized that meaningful design begins with careful observation before intervention. Understanding the landscape, its communities, and the relationships between them allows architects to ask better questions rather than rushing toward predetermined solutions. This requires embracing complexity, recognizing multiple scales of impact, and understanding that repairing social structures is often more challenging than repairing physical ones.



David also highlighted the role of the architect as a communicator and facilitator rather than a solitary expert. Architects must be able to clearly explain why their work matters, engage communities in shaping the design process, and translate ambitious ideas into small, achievable actions. A strong premise, shared with others and refined through dialogue, becomes the foundation for meaningful change.



Ultimately, David argued that architecture is about cultivating better relationships; between people, places, and the systems that sustain them. By working collaboratively, remaining grounded in genuine conviction, and creating frameworks that others can build upon, architects can move beyond isolated projects to become catalysts for long-term environmental and social transformation.

14. Final Presentations
June 19



Manuel welcomeed producers from Fragas do Eume, local politicians, and regional stakeholders, introducing the YSoA summer program: The Living Territory of Galicia.



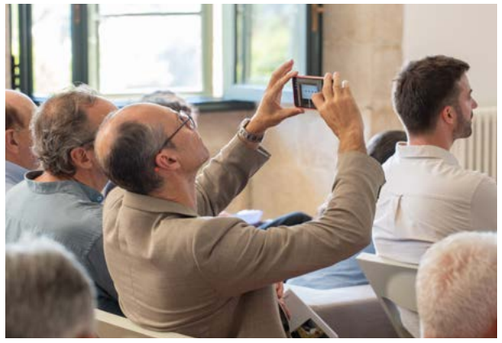
Lucía presented the work of Fundación RIA's in the Fragas, outlining the collaborative strategies and key opportunities for long-term territorial stewardship.



Julia introduced the educational program, reflecting on the workshops, lectures, field visits, and collaborative research that immersed students in the ecological, cultural, and social landscapes of Galicia over the previous three weeks.



Ana Maria presented the academic framework of the program, advocating for a design methodology rooted in territory; building relationships between ecology, culture, and community.



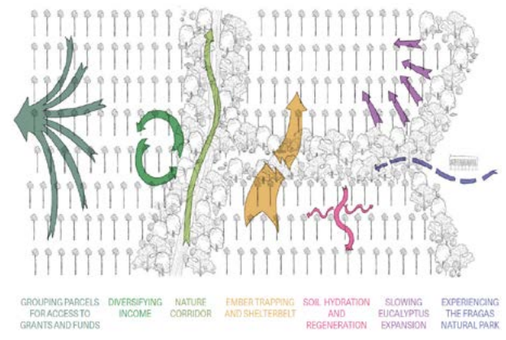
Guests included members of the Xunta de Galicia, producers, residents, and business owners from the region of Fragas do Eume.



Stakeholders took the opportunity to reflect on the the ideas presented throughout the day, and the transformative impact of the pilot projects proposed by the students.



Melos Shtaloja presented *Collective Lot Lines: From Monoculture Fragments to Polyculture Mosaics*, exploring how Galicia's fragmented cadastral system can become an asset rather than a constraint. By reimagining individual land parcels as a collectively managed mosaic, the project proposed new models of ecological restoration and shared stewardship.



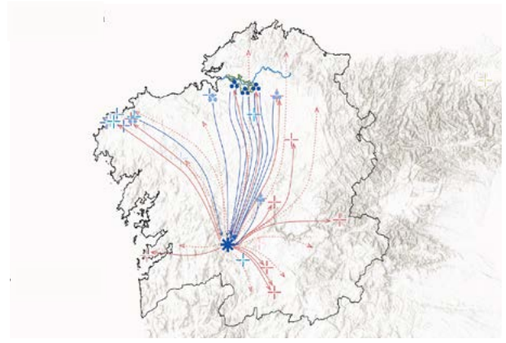


Samantha Andalon explored *Cultivating Belonging: Depopulation, Dairy, and Migration*, examining how demographic change can become an opportunity for renewal. Her proposal envisioned educational, social, and cultural programs that strengthen community identity while supporting the future of Campo Capela.



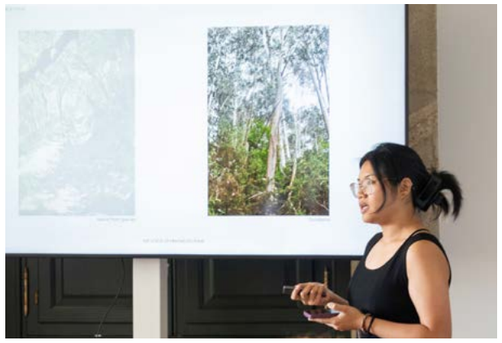


Bridgid Elrod shared *The Galician Spinning Cooperative*, reconnecting the traditions of textile production with the territory. By reintroducing flax cultivation to the Fragas do Eume, her project explored how local fiber production can revive cultural heritage, diversify agriculture, and strengthen regional economies.



14. Final Presentations

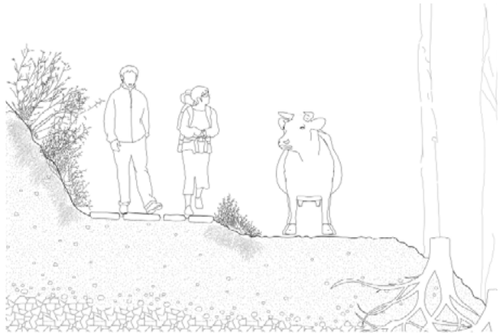
June 19





An Tran presented *Absence and Presence: The Voice of Fragas do Eume*, interpreting the landscape through sound rather than solely a visual experience. Viewing land abandonment as the silencing of culture and identity, she proposed a network for preserving the region's heritage while celebrating traditions of storytelling, poetry, music, and shared meals rooted in the land.





Myungsun Kim presented *A City Made by Walking*, proposing the restoration of historic pathways that once connected parishes across Galicia. Through interviews with local residents and examining how eucalyptus monoculture has disrupted these relationships, she considered how to reconnect people to the landscape, fostering renewed territorial stewardship.





Eva Crutan presented *Rhizomatic Mobilities*, investigating the complex relationships between permanent residents, seasonal visitors, and transient populations. Her work identified moments of intersection as opportunities for cultural exchange, knowledge sharing, and new forms of community.





Justin Morande presented *Infrastructure as Polyculture*, rethinking hydroelectric infrastructure as a community resource rather than a centralized utility. His proposal combined water monitoring, fish migration, and small-scale energy generation to reconnect local communities with the rivers that have long shaped the territory.





Yi Shi worked on *Reimagining Grazing + Wildfire Stewardship in Fragas do Eume*, focused on the relationship between grazing, wildfire prevention, and territorial stewardship by adapting existing rural infrastructure into a community protection hub. Building on traditional pastoral practices, her project reimagined shepherding as a contemporary strategy for landscape management, biodiversity, and collective resilience.

15. Shared Lunch and Reflections

June 19



Over a shared lunch celebrating products from the Fragas do Eume, guests and students exchanged ideas and reflected on the presentations. The gathering brought together stakeholders from different sectors, giving them a chance to reimagine the future of the natural park together.



The discussions presented an opportunity to connect and propose mutualistically beneficial collaborations between parties.



Next steps and potential iterations were discussed, building on the ideas proposed by the students.



The afternoon concluded with a conversation among the students, a collective reflection on the three-week program discussing experiences that were most influential in shaping their understanding of the territory and offering ideas for the continued evolution of the program.